



RAF S.E.5a

An especially robust single-seat fighter, the Royal Aircraft Factory (RAF) S.E.5a was also an exceptionally stable gun platform. As such, it is often seen as the World War I equivalent of the later Battle of Britain's Hawker Hurricane, while the lighter and more maneuverable Sopwith Camel is equated with the Supermarine Spitfire. Between them the S.E.5a and Camel reestablished Allied air superiority over the Western Front from mid-1917 until the end of the war.

DEVELOPED FROM THE S.E.5 ("SE" stood for "Scout Experimental"), which had first flown in November 1916, the S.E.5a had a more powerful 200 hp engine in place of the earlier aircraft's 150 hp unit. Designed under Henry P. Folland at the Royal Aircraft Factory's in Farnborough, the S.E.5a was dramatically better than earlier Royal Flying Corps fighters, such as the DH2 and FE8 "pushers" (biplanes with their engines and propellers mounted behind the pilot). Its "tractor" configuration, with

the propeller in the front, allowed for a clean, relatively streamlined, fast design. Its blunt, square nose lent it an air of pugnacity. In the hands of World War I Victoria Cross-holding aces, such as Albert Ball, Billy Bishop, "Mick" Mannock, and James McCudden, the SE5 and SE5a proved formidable weapons, valued for their strength and steadiness, good all-round field of vision from the cockpit, superior speed, and good performance even at high altitude.

SPECIFICATIONS	
Model	Royal Aircraft Factory S.E.5a, 1916
Origin	UK
Production	5,205 (including the S.E.5)
Construction	Wooden frames, fabric covering
Maximum weight	1,980 lb (898 kg)
Engines	200 hp Hispano-Suiza/Wolseley Viper water-cooled V8
Wingspan	26 ft 7 in (8.1m)
Length	20 ft 11 in (6.38 m)
Range	300 miles (483 km)
Top speed	138 mph (222 km/h)

